also purging suspected Hasina loyalists from major government institutions. With the police force being ineffective the law and order situation remains precarious.

Meanwhile, the Bangladesh economy has taken a southward turn since Hasina's departure. The mid-October projections by the World Bank indicated that GDP growth is likely to decelerate from 5.2 per cent in FY24 to 4.0 per cent in FY25. Inflation, driven by high food and energy prices, averaged 9.5 in FY24 and is expected to remain elevated. Unemployment rates remain significantly high, particularly in urban areas, and job creation in large industries, especially the garment sector, the backbone of the economy, has stagnated. The World Bank report also highlighted the need for urgent and bold economic reforms, but the interim government has been unable to provide a roadmap for revival yet. The country's banks are said to be in the ICU, with Ahsan Mansur, the new governor of Bangladesh's central bank, claiming that about $17 billion was siphoned off from the country's financial system in the 15 years of Hasina's rule.

THROUGH THE CRISIS, BOTH SIDES HAVE REFRAINED FROM USING PUNITIVE MEASURES LIKE DISRUPTING TRADE AND BUSINESS TIES

So, Yunus has a huge task of not only restoring the polity but also the shaky economy. The Nobel laureate has always claimed that his government's mandate is to implement reforms. In September, he formed six commissions to reform six major sectors: the electoral system, police, judiciary, public administration, the Constitution, and anti-corruption measures. All of them are expected to submit their recommendations by the end of the year. Currently, the Jatiya Nagarik Committee (national citizen's committee), formed after the uprising, along with the Anti-Discriminatory Students' Movement (ADSM) are jointly advocating sweeping political and constitutional changes. Three student leaders of the ADSM, which spearheaded the uprising against Hasina, have been inducted as advisors to the interim government and given several portfolios.

THE NEW BRAINS TRUST

Key among them is Mahfuz Alam, the liaison committee coordinator of the ADSM, who is now special assistant to Yunus. At a Clinton Global Initiative function held in New York in September, Yunus got Alam on stage and introduced him as the "brains" behind the "meticulously designed" protests that were planned and executed to oust Hasina. Indian sources allege that Alam has had links with the Jamaat's student wing—the Islami Chhatra Shibir—and also the banned extremist group Hizbut Tahrir. Sikri sees Yunus's statement as validation of the student movement not being a spontaneous uprising but backed by powerful domestic and international forces against Hasina's continuance. Indian intelligence sources claim that cadres of the Chhatra Shibir and Hefazat-e-Islam Bangladesh, another radical organisation, have infiltrated the army's officer corps. The Bangladesh army is suspected to have played a vital role in ousting Hasina by refusing to provide her any further security or act against the rioting students.

However, Alam, in a Facebook post on September 26 that was reproduced by the *Dhaka Tribune*, denied any links with these extremist organisations, saying he "didn't and still don't

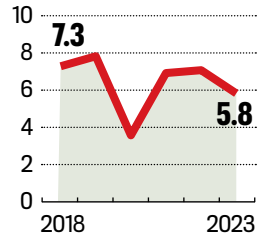
THE ECONOMIC WORRY

The pandemic and global uncertainty had already halted the path of progress Bangladesh was firmly headed toward. Now there's domestic turmoil

GDP GROWTH

After post-Covid growth of 7.1 per cent in 2022, GDP fell to 5.8 per cent in 2023

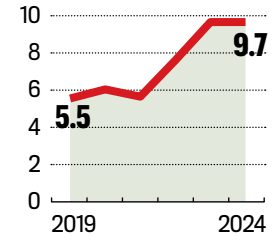
GDP growth rate (in %)



INFLATION

Inflation has seen a sharp rise in recent months

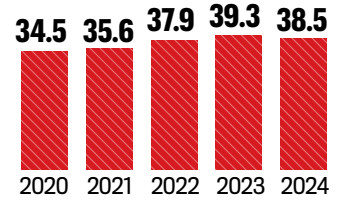
End of period consumer prices (in %)



GROSS DEBT

The country has seen a stable debt-to-GDP ratio in recent years

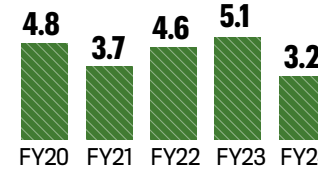
(As %age of GDP)



FISCAL DEFICIT

Fiscal deficit eased in FY24 from a four-year peak

(As %age of GDP)



Sources: World Bank; IMF; Trading Economics; Bangladesh govt

Graphic by **TANMOY CHAKRABORTY**